Sereni Fries
Always made Fresh from Natures Best!
Best quality potato products



Ten years on, Sereni Fries continues to add value to Kenya's potatoes

BY PAULINE ONGAJI

Potatoes have remained a popular food for centuries, cultivated across continents and consumed by more than a billion people.

Here in Kenya, potato dishes are diverse, and reports show that the volumes produced in the country are nearly all consumed locally.

Because of its appeal to most cultures, potato is one of the most important crops for fighting food insecurity worldwide. Locally, small-scale producers depend on its sustainable cultivation to earn income.

For this reason, there is no question that potatoes have become a staple crop for many in the world today, and is significantly contributing to the realisation of the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), including elimination of poverty, zero hunger, and stimulating economic growth.

It is against this backdrop that more investors are venturing into the industry, both in terms of enhancing the value chain and improving the lives of farmers who depend on the crop, and have not quite realised the full economic benefit from it.

One of them is Humphrey Mburu, the Managing Director of Sereni Fries Ltd. In 2012, left his job as a banker to venture into the potato industry. From what he says, the company is adding significant value to the industry across the entire chain – from production to consumption.

"We produce fresh cut products of high quality and assured safety. We have a capacity to process 200 tons of potatoes per month," he says.

The company is currently supplying fresh cut potatoes of different sizes to several food service outlets, such as hotels and restaurants.


Harvesting.

'Why we are introducing new potato concepts'

Sereni Fries Limited is planning to launch its latest product, the frozen chips, and with this introduction, offer new job opportunities. The number of employees is expected to grow from 48 to 63. In addition, the new product will broaden the company's market scope, as HUMPHREY MBURU, the Managing Director, expounds in this Q&A.

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Q. First of all, kindly fill us in on this new product.

The new product is divided into three. We have the matchstick, also known as shoestring cut. The name resembles the thinness of the chips. After frying, it has a sophisticated look and is crispier, compared to other cuts.

Then there is the medium cut, which is slightly thicker than the matchstick, but still thinner than the standard cut. It easily achieves a crunchier and 'butterlly'-feeling. And finally, we have the standard cut. This is the most common cut for fries. It has a fuller feel in the mouth, and is 'steaky' and chunkier.

I would say for best results, cook from a frozen state using the recommended temperature. Always cook until golden yellow colour and crispy, and do not overcook when doing small amounts to reduce cooking time.

Q. This is a fairly new concept to the Kenyan market. As a customer, why would I want to consume your products?

If you start making chips straight from the beginning, where you peel the potatoes, cut and make them ready for frying, it will take a lot of time. This discourages many from preparing this dish. But here, we take care of that. This product is ready for use.

For the service industry, with our product, you can easily calculate the portions from a consignment, thus helping you in terms of budgeting and monitoring your profits, unlike under normal circumstances of preparing chips from the start, making it hard to determine the exact serving from a certain amount of fresh potatoes.

Q. What makes these fries different from similar products that might exist in the market?

This product goes through three stages. The first one is blanching with water, before frying again with oil, and finally individual quick freezing, known as IQF; a technology that includes freezing the chips on their own very quickly, then storing them in a freezer. This enhances the texture and quality of the final product.

Other than that, the fact that the fries are precooked means that on your part as the consumer, you will cut on the oil, power and time needed for preparation, by 70 percent. Also, since it takes a shorter time to fry this kind of fries, the fat content is immensely reduced, making it a healthy option. Lovers of French fries can enjoy their meal without feeling guilty.

Q. Should small vegetable vendors be worried about your penetration into the potato market?

Not at all. This market will remain intact, since it mostly supplies potatoes for household use, which are quite different from what we are processing and supplying to the market.

Q. Where do you get your potatoes from?

We must admit that when it comes to fries, there are specific qualities and standards that must be adhered to. That's why we work with local farmers through contract farming. We support them from the planting stage to harvesting, to ensure that the farmer plants our desired varieties that are suitable for production of our products.

We have our agronomists spread throughout all potato growing areas, who engage directly with farmers to ensure maximum yields and quality, through trainings on proper use of farm inputs.

We are currently working with 3,500 farmers from some of the well-known potato growing regions in the country, including Nyandarua, Nakuru, Bomet, Narok, Meru, Elgeyo Marakwet and Uasin Gishu.

Q. What inspired you to adopt this model?

We decided to go this route because our potatoes are for commercial processing, thus requiring certain standards, which could only be achieved by engaging with farmers one-on-one. But also, I saw the challenges potato farmers were facing, which included market availability, and thought I could do something about it. By engaging farmers directly, we are able to buy the produce straight from the farm, and thus protect them by giving them a fair bargain by cutting out brokers, and also ensuring consistent supply to the company.

Q. How beneficial has this been?

This has been immensely favourable, not just to us as a processor, but also to the farmers. We have been able to offer farmers good prices. You see, potatoes are planted in seasons, which means that during harvest, and under normal circumstances, the prices would dwindle and farmers wouldn't get value for their input. This is where we come in and buy the crop at a fair and constant prize, unlike the middle men.

We, on the other hand, have cold potato storage facility, which enable us to store the potatoes for a long time so that we don't face fluctuations during low seasons. So, it is a win-win situation for both farmers and us as the manufacturer.

Q. Your current clients are hotels and restaurants. Who else are you eyeing in the future?

We are looking at the retail market so that it is easier for individuals to access this product. That is why we will be holding awareness campaigns to launch the new product. It will be available in supermarkets in the very near future.

We are also looking for all the players that are currently importing this product to explore ways in which we can work together to ensure that we meet the quality standards they desire.

We are looking to increase our capacity to 40 tons per day, creating products that will be very competitive. We also want to tap into the export market.

Q. What challenges have you faced as an upcoming value addition company, and what do you think should be done to boost the operations of emerging manufactures as yourself?

We have noticed that heavy investment is required to set up a proper factory. Acquiring value-addition equipment for potatoes is very expensive. That is why we feel the government should intervene on this by offering tax incentives to investors who are willing to set up such factories.

Apart from that, as a way of enhancing this industry, the government should implement deliberate measures to promote consumption of not just frozen French fries, but potato products in general. The aspect of adopting potato for food security could also be done at policy level. It will help the industry to grow.

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